

The ACT™ Framework

A three-step practice for facilitating difficult conversations without losing the relationship — Acknowledge, Check Yourself, Take Intentional Action.

Good intentions without a structure is just a really uncomfortable room. Before you open your mouth in a hard conversation, move through these three steps — in order.



Acknowledge the Signal

SOMETHING HAS HAPPENED

Take in the information with neutrality before you react. Practice a simple internal phrase — *“isn’t that interesting...”* — to create distance from the story you want to tell yourself.

A

ASK YOURSELF

- Does this need to be addressed?
- Is it mine to address?
- Do I need to facilitate a conversation between team members?
- What could happen if it remains unresolved?



Check Yourself

SELF-AWARENESS IS NOT OPTIONAL

We are never completely neutral - not when we care about the people involved. Self-awareness is knowing what’s going on inside you and how that affects what’s happening around you. Checking yourself is not a detour. It’s the work.

C

ASK YOURSELF

- What am I feeling, assuming, and intending?
- Am I ready to respond productively?
- How am I feeling today — do I have the bandwidth to confront this?
- What could the fallout be? What are the implications?



Take Intentional Action

AWARENESS CREATES THE PAUSE - ACTION CREATES THE CHANGE

Interrupt your automatic pattern and make a conscious choice: avoid this, confront this now, or postpone this strategically. If you postpone, hold yourself to a 24-hour rule - behavior not addressed will not change.

T

CHOOSE DELIBERATELY

- **Confront now** — when there’s an immediate safety or standards concern (use STOP: Stop the action, Tell what you observed, Outline the safe next step, Proceed only when safe).
- **Postpone strategically** — when emotions are hot, you’re rushed, or others are watching. Wait no more than 24 hours.
- **Never avoid indefinitely** — that’s what builds layers under the rug.

“Between stimulus and response there is a space. In that space is our power to choose. In our choice lies our growth and our freedom. - Viktor Frankl



The CORE™ Framework

A conversation you build together, not a script you deliver. Share one piece, pause, listen, then move forward.

CORE stands for Context, Observation, Result, and Expectation. Rehearsing a full case and delivering it like a closing argument turns a conversation into a courtroom — and nobody in a courtroom feels psychologically safe. Instead, share one element at a time and pause to listen before continuing.

Context

WHY WE ARE TALKING

Tell the other person why you're having this conversation and what the goal is. This lowers the threat level- it communicates that you're not there to win, you're there to work it out.

SAMPLE LINE:

"Sally, thanks for taking a few minutes. I want to talk about how we're communicating and work on best practices so we can work really well together."

PAUSE & ASK: "Can we talk about what's been happening?"

Observation

WHAT YOU ACTUALLY SAW

State the facts without blame - not what you concluded, not what you assumed, not what you think it means about the other person's character.

SAMPLE LINE:

"Over the last few weeks, I've noticed that you've come out of the huddle several times and told me what you needed me to do without asking whether I was available or explaining what support you needed."

PAUSE & ASK: "Can you help me understand what's going on?"

Result

THE ACTUAL IMPACT

Connect the behavior to its consequence in a way the other person can actually hear. Not a punishment, not an accusation - the real effect it has on you and the working relationship.

SAMPLE LINE:

"When that happens, I feel frustrated, and it creates tension between us. It makes it harder for us to communicate and work well together."

PAUSE & ASK: "How are you experiencing our communication?"

Expectation

WHAT CHANGE LOOKS LIKE

Replace words like "do better" with something specific, so the other person knows exactly what to do differently moving forward - and has a say in it.

SAMPLE LINE:

"Going forward, I'd like you to ask for my help instead of telling me what to do, and explain what you need from me."

PAUSE & ASK: "What do you need from me, and what can we agree to do differently?"